

‘worth it’, that only XYZ would make me feel whole and good, I struggle not to reach for fast fashion or beauty products as a quick-fix solution to a bad mood – and I know that I’m not alone in this. It can be really difficult to tell what we’re genuinely doing for ourselves, to enjoy or relax us, and what we’re spending in an attempt to cancel out the various stresses that come along with modern life. As lovely as an aromatherapy massage is, it’s not an antidote to an overwhelming mental load. It’s a bit like trying to put out a fire with a thimbleful of water – and it doesn’t make any difference if the water is lavender-scented.

What’s more, there is a weird tendency in the press and on social media to conflate self-care and personal grooming, the latter of which is really just a single element of looking after yourself. Actual self-care is complex, and sometimes it’s *hard*. It doesn’t just mean buying yourself whatever you want, all the time, or doing whatever you feel like at any given moment. It often means holding yourself accountable and practising self-discipline. Sometimes self-care is giving yourself a break, but sometimes it’s doing the hard thing, or the annoying little thing that’s been lingering on your to-do list for months.

Sometimes the hardest part of looking after ourselves can be working out what we do actually need, especially if we’ve been conditioned to reach for commercial solutions to our tiredness and discontent. I spoke to psychologist and author Suzy Reading, whose books on self-care contain some of the most nourishing, insightful advice I’ve ever read on this topic.